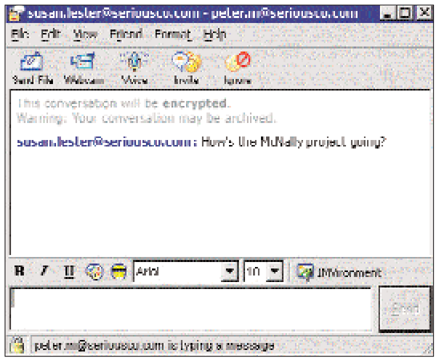
company resources. Banning their use completely is a shortsighted solution, which ignores their potential contribution to the company. Organisations must develop their own policies for IM usage within the company. Besides, whilst implementing business grade IMs, a corporate policy must be in place to determine the nature of their use. Monitoring usage is the proverbial hot-potato—with CIOs wanting to know exactly what their employees are up to, and privacy advocates crying foul. Some companies already archive e-mails to monitor leakage of sensitive data. One can only assume that, as IMs becomes more pervasive, a similar system will be implemented for it too.

Besides, for text messaging, today's IM clients provide the basis for much richer forms of communication. Voice, and even video, can be carried over the same networks that carry text. Consumer IMs integrate all the facilities you need, into the clients. Once your audio is properly set up, starting a voice conversation with anyone on your contact list is just a couple of clicks away. The same can be said about video, assuming that both parties have Web cams.

Long distance calls, even to regular phones, are now being made through the Internet because of the cost advantage it enjoys. Calls through the Net, made using the services of Indian providers such as Phonewala.com, costs about Rs 5 per minute. International providers are even cheaper. These calls work on a technology called Voice over IP (VoIP). Simply put, the voice is encoded and compressed, then sent over the Internet as data packets—just like regular Internet traffic would be—and are decoded back to audio at the other end. It takes a lot of data to transfer very little audio. This means that the demands placed on the network are relatively high, often leading to poor quality of service. This network limitation usually exists at the so-called last mile, i.e, the connection between the home or office and the ISP. Connections between the phone provider's servers the world over, are generally speedy enough not to be an issue.



Yahoo! Messenger Enterprise Edition has 'professional' written all over it

Here's an idea to solve the last mile link problem, and eliminate the PC in the bargain. Users can call the phone provider's server directly using his standard phone. This keeps the voice as voice, until it reaches the server. The voice is then encoded and decoded at the servers, and transferred between them over the Internet at high speeds, providing much better voice clarity, and less delay.

We have already seen the integration of MSN messenger into Windows XP in the form of Windows Messenger. The next logical evolution is the integration of communication tools within our applications, allowing for better collaboration. Microsoft will soon release its own enterprise-grade IM server that will be branded as part of the office suite. Office Real-Time Communications Server 2003 (RTC) will be part of Microsoft's Office system of programs, servers and services. RTC is a server, which allows organization users to communicate in real time over managed networks, securely. RTC will also be extensible, allowing developers to integrate real time communication into their own applications. Microsoft touts the benefits of integration with other office apps as 'collaboration in context', which reduces decision-making time, and increases efficiency. For example, when you're reading an e-mail in Outlook, you will be able to see if the sender is online, and initiate an IM conversation. The IM conversation may resolve the issue, or turn out to be more efficient than the usual process of mailing a reply, and then waiting for a response. Another place where the integration will be evident is the new SharePoint Portal Server. Using SharePoint, companies can make their own portals for their organization, or each departmental team may have their own portal.

One thing is certain about the future. More and more communication will happen over the Internet. Time and time again, it has proven to be endlessly extensible, adapting to future requirements, and taking on new roles with increasing bandwidths. Text, voice, video and data all help us do business faster and bring us closer together—all thanks to the wonder that is the World Wide Web.

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Audio Setup

Using IMs, you can now initiate a voice conversation with your pal. The Audio Setup feature, present in most IMs, checks the audio peripherals, and analyses the quality of sound received, and transmitted.

Yahoo!

The first time you attempt to make a call in Yahoo! Messenger, it will automatically launch the Audio Setup Wizard. To do this, go to ***Tools*** > ***Call...*** Follow the instructions on screen, to complete the setup. The wizard even sets up echo reduction, and tests your connection's quality. After the wizard completes, it takes you to the phone interface, from where you can make long distance calls via Net2Phone's service. To have a voice chat with others on your contact list, double-click their name, and click the Voice icon, which is just below the menu bar.

MSN

MSN Messenger also launches its own Audio Tuning Wizard when you first try to have a voice conversation with any of your contacts. To initiate it, right-click on a contact, and from the menu, select 'Start an Audio Conversation'. Follow the steps to complete the tuning.

Unified messaging centre

ICQ offers several types of web panels, each with its own unique functionality. Choose one that offers all the functionality that you need without blocking up too much of your Web page. Check them out, and get the code to insert them into your page at ***http://www.icq.com/panels/***.

ICQ Web-Pager Panel lets your site's visitors send messages straight to your ICQ.